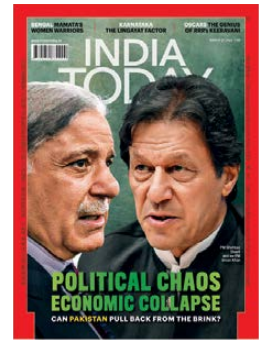
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Pakistan's history has shown it to be a bonsai democracy. Lurching from army rule to sporadic elections. Sometimes, though, the bonsai can surprise the gardener (read the Army) by sprouting some unexpected shoots. So it was on February 11, with a stunning set of election results. Imran Khan, the charismatic but fallen hero of a self-styled renaissance, nearly pulled off a match against all odds. In Pakistan's case these days, that means Army Chief General Asim Munir—the ultimate arbiter of all political destinies.

The swashbuckling former cricket captain had been deposed in April 2022, after falling afoul of the Army, which had propelled him to the PM's post in 2018. He has been under arrest since August 2023, and has copped sentences running for up to 14 years in three back-to-back convictions. His party, the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI), was formally debarred from contesting—its election symbol, the cricket bat, was frozen. Imran, however, managed to cock a snook at his larger-than-life foes from inside prison. That too without any political party, election symbol or flag—all of which the election commission banned. Those affiliated with Imran's PTI, forced to contest as Independents, won 93 out of 266 seats in the National Assembly. Though well short of the 134 required for a majority, its seat share was the largest among all parties. Nawaz Sharif's Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N) won only 75 seats. The Bilawal Bhutto-led Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) came in third, with 54 seats.



March 27, 2023

Meanwhile, Nawaz, who was ousted as PM in 2017, the final year of his third term, was rehabilitated after spending much of the past six years in disgrace, including a four-year exile that threatened to be permanent. His past criminal convictions and misdemeanours, including his run-ins with the army brass, were pardoned in order to enable the Establishment to politically checkmate Imran.

The spectre of fragmented election results extended into the provincial assembly elections that were held simultaneously. The PTI again won a moral victory here. It wrested an overwhelming majority in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, winning 84 out of its 115 general seats, and getting in line to control the administration in the frontier province. Even more mortifyingly for Sharif, the PTI also split the vote right down the middle in his home base, Punjab, taking 116 seats against the PML-N's 137 out of 297 general seats—leaving neither in control. But enough for the PML-N to cobble together a coalition to rule what is politically Pakistan's most powerful province. The country's third big player, the PPP, retained its own provincial stronghold of Sindh with 84 out of 130 seats. Balochistan had an intriguing three-way split.

In sum, the deeply divided political landscape was filled with stunted figures, making it easier for the Army to again stamp its authority on proceedings—persuading mutually dependent parties into a coalition of the willing. That resulted in the PML-N and PPP joining hands, as they had done soon after Imran was ousted in 2022 by forming the Pakistan Democratic Movement (PDM). After hard rounds of negotiations, Nawaz Sharif yielded to the demand that his brother Shehbaz be made the prime minister, while his daughter Maryam was given the prize of being chief minister of Punjab. Ensuring his daughter's succession as a leader of the party was one of Nawaz's main aims upon his return. Also, given the fragile mandate, his move to step back was seen as him being kept in reserve if the going gets tough for Shehbaz. Moreover, Shehbaz has always enjoyed good rapport with the Army and Munir, too, is comfortable working with him, while Nawaz has always exhibited an independent streak.

The Bilawal-led PPP also played its cards carefully. It demanded that all the key constitutional posts be given to it, including that of the President, the Speaker of the National Assembly, chairmanship of the Senate and the governorship of the four provinces. The party is also planning to extend only outside support to the PDM 2.0 coalition without demanding any cabinet positions. The idea is to distance itself from any unpopularity the new government would accrue, thereby retaining for itself a shot at power if things went south.

Bilawal is acutely aware that Shehbaz now wears a crown of thorns. Pakistan's economy hangs by a thread: growth is in contraction mode, inflation is nearly 40 per cent, external debt is projected to swell to $130.85 billion in 2023-24 from $123.57 billion in 2022-23. So, the IMF, whose next bailout package is due by March, and other benefactors like China and Saudi Arabia, will all extract their pound of flesh before offering their lifelines. This will be a test for the Sharifs. Even if the Army keeps an eagle eye on governance from Rawalpindi GHQ, this is not necessarily the sort of bridgehead army generals are good at plotting to conquer.

Though in prison, Imran's shadow still looms large. The Army has not forgotten or forgiven him for the anarchic 'insurrection' against the military by PTI hordes last summer. And now they have a democratic replay of that defiance, with PTI defeating a media blackout with digital guerrilla tactics, including an AI-generated Imran. There is likely to be the predictable rituals whereby the Army would nudge the Imran-backed Independents to shift their loyalties to the new 'King's party' to nullify Imran's parliamentary clout.

But one thing the Establishment is good at everywhere is keeping itself established. Our cover story this week, by Karachi-based journalist Hasan Zaidi, a long-time contributor to the magazine, comes fresh from the ground. It tells a tale that's both strikingly novel and dripping with déjà vu. Just keep one fact in mind as you watch the new political drama play out: No Pakistan prime minister has ever been able to serve his or her full term since its Independence.

Meanwhile, ties between India and Pakistan reached a new nadir in 2019. After India abrogated Article 370, Pakistan angrily expelled India's High Commissioner in Islamabad and snapped all trade, transport and cultural ties. Since then, Pakistan continues to make settling Kashmir as the core issue for resuming relations. India's approach has been that while it is willing to improve relations with Pakistan, Islamabad has to end its core policy of using cross-border terrorism to get Delhi to the table for talks. The problem has always been that the Army's hostility towards India has been its raison d'etre. However, every new dispensation in Islamabad does bring a sliver of hope for change, so India will wait and watch.

(Aroon Purie)